Parent Handbook

2025-26

ACTON UPCOUNTRY

Courage • Character • Calling

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Goal of this handbook ...

Philosophy of our Operations



To equip parents with the "how to" of daily operations at Acton Upcountry so they may support their children's Hero's Journeys and soar on their own family's journey.

There are three underlying values that drive every policy and system created for our community to function and achieve our mission:

1. Freedom for families. We believe parents, not communities, are in charge of their families, and we trust you to make your own choices for your families.

2. Sanctity of studios as learning spaces for Learners only. This includes basic safety as well as protection against interruptions, distractions and the threat of lowering standards of excellence.

3. Sanctity of parent/child relationships. We will not come between you and your child. This means we will not answer parent questions about studio experiences or observations without the permission of the child and the child's involvement in the conversation (in Threshold studios and above).

"At Acton, we believe every child is a genius and deserves to find a calling that will change the world"

What is the Hero's Journey



Do you long to make your life into an adventure? Have you ever pursued a worthy goal, fighting against seemingly insurmountable challenges and even longer odds, and yet persevered until the Grail was in your hands, only to find what was most important was how you changed in the process? If you answered yes to these questions, you understand the Hero's Journey at a visceral level.

At Acton Upcountry, your child's learning journey will follow a similar arc, and the Hero's Journey metaphor will be embedded in their daily life, session long Quests, Badge Plans, yearly learning arcs, as well as life beyond Acton Upcountry . Each day, week, session and year will be like a Call to Adventure. With Guides and peers as allies and helpers, your Learner will discover their safe zones and challenge zones, and will go through ebbs and flows of trials and celebrations. Be prepared for an exciting ride!

Fast Facts

683 Naalae Road, Kula, HI 96790

www.actonacademykula.org

808.344.6923

All staff email:
ActonAcademyKula@gmail.com

Studio Names // Ages

Spark	Threshold	Explorer	Launch Pad
ages 5-8	ages 8-12	ages 12-14	ages 15-18

Schedule:

Monday - Thursday: 8:30am-3pm

Friday: 9am-noon

Enrollment Options:

- 4 Days/Week (Monday-Thursday)

Tuition rates are subject to an increase each year.

The Purpose of Acton Upcountry



Our Mission

Acton Upcountry's mission is to inspire each person who enters our doors to find a calling and change the world.

Our Beliefs

- We believe each child has a gift that can change the world in a profound way.
- We believe in learning to learn, learning to do and learning to be.
- We believe in a closely connected community of lifelong Learners.
- We believe in economic, political and religious freedom.

Our Promises

We promise your children will...

- Begin a Hero's Journey
- Learn to be curious, independent, lifelong Learners
- Develop a deep respect for economic, political, and religious freedoms
- Cherish the arts, wonders of the physical world and the mysteries of life on Earth
- Discover his or her most precious gifts and learn to use them to solve difficult problems.

"The cave you fear to enter holds the treasure you seek."

Accountability

Covenants and Contracts

Creating clear, consistent expectations for Acton Upcountry families are an important part of our community. As such, the parents, Learners and Guides will reaffirm this commitment by signing a covenant each year that describes the roles and responsibilities to which we are agreeing.

The purpose of this living document is not to promote rule-following or bureaucracy but rather the opposite: to draw clear boundaries to encourage innovation between Learners, parents and Guides who through commitment and action show support for the creation of a world-class community.

Hero Contract

(NOTE: This is the temporary contract until the Heroes write their own during the first weeks of the new year)

I promise to:

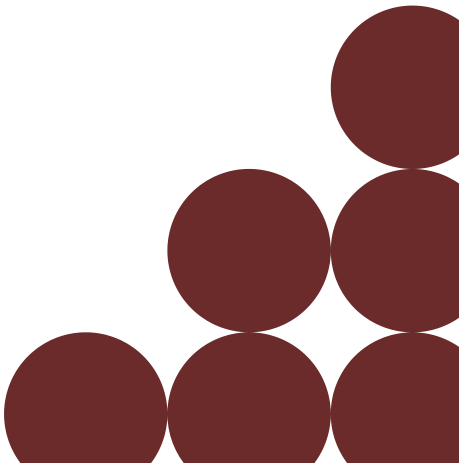
- Work hard and play well with kindness and respect
- Help keep the studio clean and safe
- Admit honestly when I make a mistake and accept the natural consequences of my actions.

If I fail to deliver on these promises, I understand that I may suffer natural consequences, which will be laid out in advance. These may include being separated from the community, being asked to stay home for some period of time, or even being asked to leave the community.

Signed: _____

"Curiosity is the engine of achievement."

-Sir Ken Robinson



Accountability

Covenants and Contracts

Parents and Guides also sign contracts to uphold their end of the promises. At the end of this handbook is a checklist and our Parent Contract. Please sign and return it before your child enters the studio. This is your pledge to support your child'sHero's Journey and accept this call to adventure!

Guide Contract

I promise to deliver on Acton Upcountry's promises and will:

• Provide challenges, mileposts, rewards, and guardrails to inspire and equip each of our Heroes.

• Present processes, frameworks, examples, recipes, and hard questions for Heroes to use.

• Allow Heroes to learn from failure and natural consequences, when necessary.

• Affirm each Hero's gifts, listen and praise effort, especially when the path is difficult.

• Celebrate as Heroes take on more and more of a Guide's responsibilities and move from being an Independent Learner to Running Partner, Socratic Leader, Project Leader, and Organization Leader.

If I fail to deliver on these promises, I invite Learners to comment on the surveys, which are taken very seriously by all Guides and the owners of the community. Guides who continually fail to uphold these promises will no longer be allowed to serve at Acton Upcountry.

"The goal of schools shouldn't be to manufacture "productive citizens" to fill some corporate cubicle; it should be to inspire each child to find a "calling" that will change the world."
— Clark Aldrich, Unschooling Rules
Cormorant Garamond
Cormorant Garamond

Accountability

Parent Contract

As parents at Acton Upcountry :

1. We long for our Learner to discover a calling that will change the world. We will allow our Learner to fail early and cheaply as they gain the skills to be a lifelong Learner. We will support with love rather than stepping in to take the struggle away or to fix their problems for them.

2. We align with Acton Upcountry as a self-paced environment where Learners run the studios through the delegation of certain rights by owners and parents, with access to experts for instruction, allowing Guides to focus on an engaging set of challenges and questions.

3. We will celebrate our Learner's progress according to a learning plan we create, and act at home if needed, to remove distractions like gaming, video, or social media.

4. Further, for our own Hero's Journeys as parents: As parents at Acton Upcountry:



• We will remain lifelong Learners and each will have an active learning project (such as a book or self-improvement project) at all times to discuss with our children.

• At least one of us will attend at least two of the three Parent Meetings each year, where Socratic discussions will focus on our Hero's Journey as parents.

• We will bring our Learner to campus before 8:55 am and understand that Learners who arrive late may not be able to participate in that morning's activities.

Signed: _____

Hours & Attendance

Daily Life

If your child will be absent, please notify the Guide by text or email in the morning or as soon as possible.

Arrival starts at 8:30 am. To reinforce the Acton value of self-responsibility, we ask that you say your goodbyes at the car. When the Learner arrives to the entrance of the studio, the Guide greets the Learner with a handshake, greeting, and eye contact, which is the customary start to our day together. From 8:30 to 8:55 am, Learners engage in free time, reading, socializing and getting organized for the day. The morning launch starts promptly at 9 am.

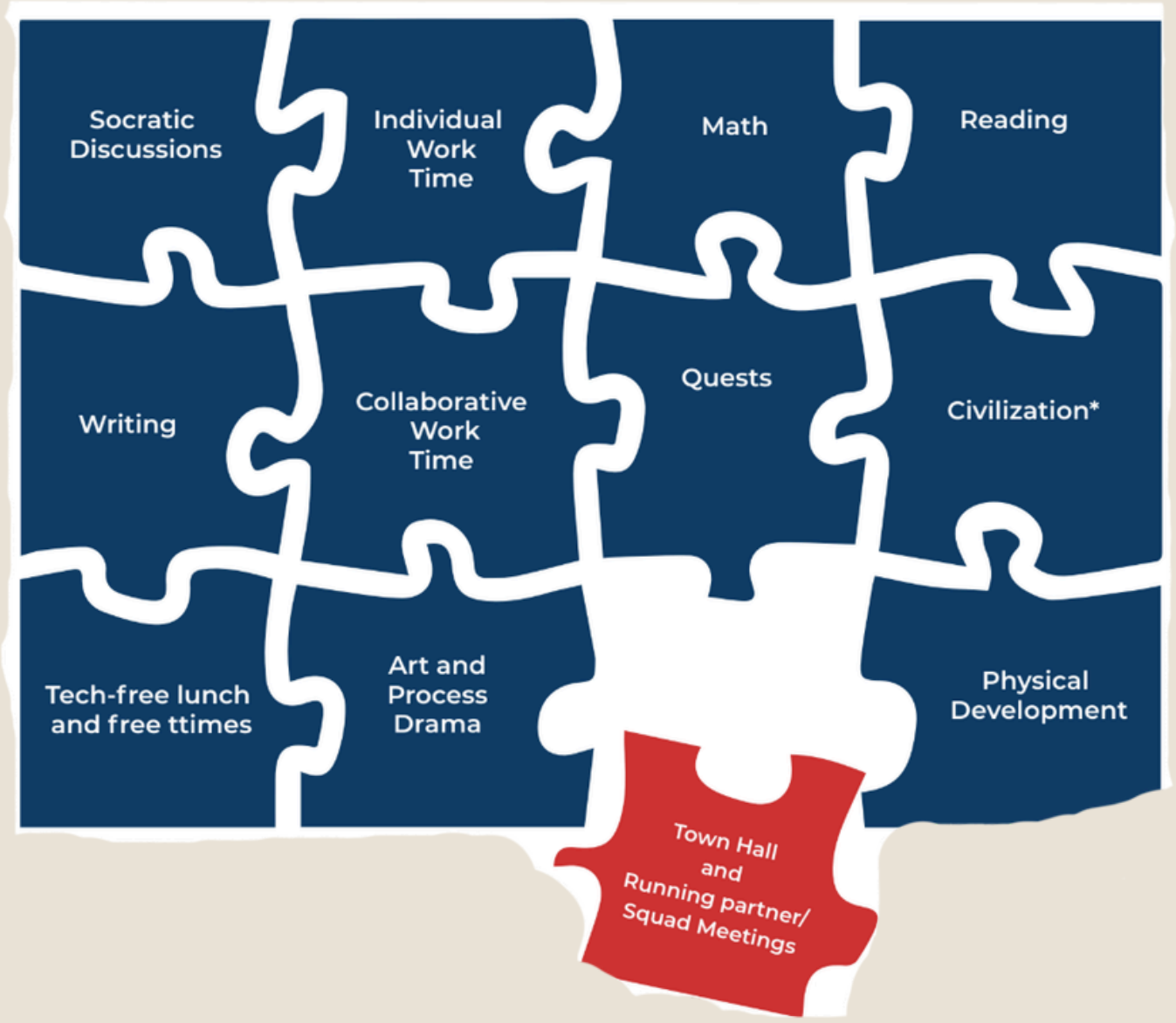
In order not to interrupt others who will be focusing on the morning launch discussion, a latecomer is required to enter quietly without disrupting the discussion. In addition to learning the life skill of showing up on time every time, these discussions are critical parts of the daily learning at Acton Upcountry. If arriving late is a repeated occurrence or if the Learner cannot enter quietly, then the Guide may ask the Learner to wait outside until the discussion is over. ***We allow up to 3 tardies per session.***

Pickup starts at 2:30 but dismissal is at 3:00 pm sharp.

You are in charge of being clear with your child about who is driving him or her home if it is someone other than yourself. Your child should be confident and knowledgeable about the people who are allowed by you to drive him or her home. This is not a Guide's nor Acton Upcountry's responsibility (except in the case of a last minute emergency). It is a family responsibility. If your child is ever confused by who is there to drive home, he or she should go immediately to the Guide to request help.

Learning Arcs @ Acton Upcountry

The learning design at Acton Upcountry is made up of several moving parts. Each day, Learners will participate in focused individual work time with Core Skills like reading, writing and math, collaborate with peers in Civilization Discussions and Quests, and participate as contributing tribe members in Town Halls and Squad Meetings. Each piece completes the learning arc puzzle.



SUPPLIES: TOOLS FOR THE JOURNEY

CHROMEBOOKS

An integral part of our program is using technology for Heroes to learn math, reading and writing skills at their own pace. We provide one laptop per Learner as needed to use during the day on campus. They are community property. If one is damaged or lost by a Learner, the family is responsible for reimbursing the community in the amount of $200 that will be added to your tuition bill.

In addition, if any part of the community campus is intentionally damaged by a Learner, he or she will assist in the repair. Your child is responsible for the care of any personal items brought to community.

What to bring with you ?

Items to Bring on the First Day of School

- **A Complete Set of Extra Clothes**:
  - This includes a pair of socks, underwear, a short sleeve top (or dress), a long sleeve top, and a pair of bottoms (shorts, pants or leggings). When soiled clothing goes home, please send replacements back to school the next day for your child's extra clothes bag. Please mark your child's belongings with their name or initials.
- **Rain Gear**:
  - Waterproof rain boots and a waterproof rain jacket to be used for water play, rainy days, and garden work.
- **Indoor Slippers or Socks**:
  - Well-fitting, washable slippers or thick warm socks with non-skid bottoms work well. Regular socks work, too

Items to Bring to School Daily:

- **Reading book of their choice.**
- **A Water Bottle with Water:**
  - We will refill with filtered water, as needed.
- **Morning and Afternoon Snacks/Hearty Lunch:**
  - Ideas include: a main course, such as a sandwich, leftover dinner, burrito, etc.), fruits, vegetables, nuts, cheese and crackers, and other favorite foods. Please avoid desserts with added sugar. *Keep in mind that food sent in lunches cannot be reheated (a thermos works great!) and including a cold pack helps to keep perishable foods cool. One to be used as a place mat and the other as a napkin. Please also include utensils if needed (we will have a limited number of utensils available for when they are left at home on occasion).*
- **Sturdy Play Shoes/Rain Boots**:
  - Closed-toe shoes or sturdy sandals that strap in the toes and heels are recommended for outdoor play. Children are welcome to wear slippers or be barefoot, but it's always good to have an alternative for digging and water play.

Toys from Home: We ask that toys from home do not come to school. If your child wants to bring something to share with the class on *Show & Share* days, we welcome something sentimental, handmade, or items from nature. But details about Show and Share will be communicated once we begin in our second week of school.

Health and Wellbeing

MEDICATION

Learners may not carry medicine into the community. Parents must give the medicine and written instructions to a Guide. For prescription medicine, please send the medicine in the original container from the pharmacy with the child's name on it and a dated note listing the times and amounts to be given that day. Include whether or not refrigeration is required.

ILLNESS POLICY

Learning at Acton Upcountry is very collaborative and we often work in close proximity to other Learners. If your child has any of the below symptoms, please keep him or her home until symptom free.

- Fever
- Diarrhea
- Vomiting
- Nausea
- Severe cough
- Unusual yellow color to skin or eyes
- Stiff neck or headache with one or more of the symptoms listed above
- Wheezing or difficulty breathing
- Complaints of severe pain.

If your child is not feeling well in the morning, please observe them carefully before sending them to community. Children must be free of the above symptoms for 24 hours before returning to community. If your child develops any of these symptoms while at Acton Upcountry, we will call you immediately to come pick up your child.

A Community of Heroes

PHILOSOPHY

The Guides support the Heroes in learning how to be a friend and a contributing member of the community. This includes understanding that every choice has a consequence.

SYSTEMS OF ACCOUNTABILITY

STRIKE SYSTEM: A MODELING OF CHOICES AND CONSEQUENCES

If a choice was made to

Intentionally harm another Learner (emotionally or physically)	Engage in unsafe behavior that endangers others or self	Intentionally misuse/break materials including using electronics for entertainment or inappropriate uses.

THEN

A strike will be given by the Guide.
Strikes are the natural consequences of these choices.

Continued...

Strike 1

If the Learner makes a choice that falls outside of the safety boundaries of the studio:

- Hero takes a reset break away from the group for a short time until regulated.
- The Guide speaks with the Hero to ensure he/she understands why he/she is receiving a strike. The Guide points the Hero to the Contract and asks "Can you see how holding you accountable for your actions (by issuing the strike) is operating within your Studio Contract of Promises?"
- The Guide works with the Hero to brainstorm specific strategies to prevent a second strike.
- The Guide sends an email to the parents (based on studio age, appropriateness, and severity).

Strike 2

If the Learner makes a choice that falls outside of the safety boundaries of the studio:

- Everything from First Strike process above.

Strike 3

If the Learner again makes a choice outside the safety boundaries:

- Everything from First / Second Strike process above.
- Based on age appropriateness and the Guide's discretion, the Hero is sent home for the day. Upon returning, the Hero will write a letter taking full responsibility for their actions, recommit to Acton's systems, and 2-3 strategies for success moving forward.
- The studio will celebrate the Hero's return and honor the process of learning from failures.

Generally, if a Hero receives two violations within an academic year, they are electing to leave the community. This will be decided according to the Guide and Head of School's discretion.

FRESH EYES:
Celebrating the return of a Learner

The definition of Hero at Acton is one who gets back up after falling down; or apologizes after making a mistake. The community is always happy when a Hero makes the choice to join back up with the group. There is a tradition of joy and forgiveness as resolution to these experiences that are bound to happen to each Hero on this adventure of learning.

Note: If this cycle of a third strike being received is repeated, a Transition Contract is put in place. The Guide, the Hero, and the parents will meet to discuss whether Acton Upcountry is the best place for the Hero's learning. If so, the Contract is read together and any questions are answered. The Hero signs the Contract and returns by its conditions.

SAMPLE TRANSITION CONTRACT

• I promise to honor and uphold the Studio Guardrails and Studio Contract, including: Be kind and respectful. Hold the studio sacred.

• I promise to earn at least 1 new Badge.

• I promise to call out at least one Learner during Character Call Outs each week. If I uphold this contract as a Hero through (agreed upon date) , I understand that it will be cause to celebrate, for advancing on my Hero's Journey and helping make Acton Upcountry an effective place for Heroes to learn and grow. If I choose to break this contract, I understand that I will be asked not to return to Acton Upcountry .

Signed _____

We promise to encourage and support (our Learner) on his journey and to hold him accountable to his
promises.

_____ _____
Parent Signature Date

FOLLOWING ALONG

Staying informed on your child's Hero's Journey in a Learning Driven Way

WHAT DOES LEARNER DRIVEN REALLY MEAN?

A Learner Driven Community is different from a student centered classroom. The community comes together with these 10 essential elements, bound by the grounding belief that every child is a genius. The elements are:

1. The Hero's Journey
2. Growth Mindset
3. Contracts
4. Mixed Ages
5. The Socratic Method
6. Trial and Error Learning
7. Excellence
8. Freedom and Responsibility
9. Public Exhibitions
10. Sheepdog leaders become Guides

You can support your Learner in this journey by trusting them to lead the way, and asking them for information.
You are also welcome to reach out to a Guide or the Head of School with any questions or concerns.

SMART GOALS AND JOURNEY TRACKER

We trust parents to take the initiative to understand and support their child's weekly goals and badge plans. This is a large part of your journey as an Acton parent and takes an intentional effort. Your Learner will be able to share login and password information with you so you have access to the online programs as well as the Acton "Journey Tracker."

Ask your child to give you a tour of their work and explain the Tracker to you. Talking through the programs with your child (with you as "student" and your child as "teacher") is the most effective way for you to feel equipped. Most importantly, we encourage you to talk with your child about SMART goals. Asking questions about where they are feeling challenged, frustrated and excited can help you encourage them with growth mindset praise and celebrate achievements with them.

Remembering that learning is hard and struggling is part of the journey will help you stress less and share patience with your child.

FOLLOWING ALONG

How do I know what is going on and talk with my children about their learning?

This page on Growth Mindset Praise, adapted from Carol Dweck's "Mindset: The New Psychology of Success," will equip you with the language that can best motivate your child towards independence and progress in learning. Research on praise and mindset shows that when we praise children for being smart, it promotes a fixed mindset. It sends a message that their accomplishments are trait-based, and tied to something innate. In contrast, **praising children for working hard promotes a growth mindset.** It sends a message that the child's effort is what led them to success.

Say This:

"I can see you worked so hard on this!"
"It seems like it's time to try a new strategy."
"I like watching you do that."
"It looks like that was too easy for you. Let's find you something challenging so your brain can grow."
"That was really hard. Your effort has paid off! Next time you'll be ready for this kind of challenge!"
"You've worked hard to become a good writer. You should challenge yourself and learn something you don't know how to do yet."

Not That

"You are so smart!"
"It's okay. Maybe you're just not cut out for this!"
"You're a natural at that!"
"That's right! You did that so quickly and easily; great job!"
"That was really hard. I'm so glad it's over and you don't have to do that again."
"You have a real talent for writing. You should take a creative writing class because you're so good at it."

Stay Connected

We plan monthly family connection activities and exhibitions at the end of each session. We know that the families that make the most effort to connect to others in our community have a more enriching experience. Parents are strongly encouraged to attend a minimum of 2 family events each year. These events are planned to provide intentional guidance and support for families throughout their time at Acton Upcountry.

FOLLOWING ALONG

How do I know what is going on and talk with my children about their learning?

PARENT BLOG

Please note: Acton Upcountry does not give parenting advice and we do not get in between you and your child. We trust your personal choices regarding discipline or parental authority and have absolutely zero input on your personal family life. Each family is unique and we trust you to make your own best choices.

We do, however, offer you tools to help you incorporate the Acton method of asking questions and offering choices with consequences if you wish to use these at home. Being an Acton parent is a unique calling. Your child will bring home new skills and ideas gained from learning in a Socratic way. They will be more independent in their learning and more able to share their ideas and make personal decisions. It is a challenge to be on the other end of this transformation as a parent.

The blog written by Laura Sandefer is geared to help parents understand what happens in the studios in order to incorporate the method at home in ways that support the family's mission. Laura comes to the blog as a parent with challenges and struggles and not an expert giving advice. **The address is: www.actonacademyparents.com.**

CONTACTING GUIDES

It is our philosophy that Guides may not come between a child and a parent. You are the main authority and shepherd of your child's education and we are here to support you but with limitations. Since Guides move between studios and have contact with all Learners, communication with parents is done through a common email noted below. If you wish to direct your email to a particular Guide, simply address your note to him or her but use the common email address noted below. The information on the emails is kept strictly confidential between the Guides. Feel free to call or text.

Please understand that we will not be available to talk with you in detail about your child during the morning drop off. Email is the most effective communication. Guides have phones only for emergencies and are not able to take calls or texts during the day.

The Guide email is : **ActonAcademyKula@gmail.com**

In case of an emergency at community, you will receive a group text as well as a group email with instructions.

Continued...

SURVEYS EACH SESSION

As part of our commitment to families, each family will receive a survey via a Google Form each session. Your responses will be kept anonymous from the community. We ask that you participate each session as we strive to improve and communicate effectively. The summary of these surveys will be shared with fellow Acton Upcountry families and Guides each session. By sharing the results, we uphold our shared value of transparency and accountability to you. The survey is a place for constructive input. The results are also shared as part of our commitment to our network.

We encourage parents to find a healthy involvement in their child's learning that works for their family. You have many tools available for this (see next page.) Documentation of weekly goal achievement is available for Learners to share with their parents at any time. Your child can show you how to log into Journey Tracker to see the work accomplished and in progress. In addition, you are encouraged to become familiar with your child's online learning sites. Simply ask your child to teach you how to log in and give you a "tour." As a minimum, we encourage parents to ask their children about their goal setting at the beginning of the week; and follow up at the end of the week. It is helpful to ask questions like:

- What would you do differently?
- Do you feel that your work this week was the best you can do?
- Where are you feeling most challenged?
- What was your greatest achievement this week?
- What was your greatest failure?
- When did you have the most energy today?
- When did you serve as a Guide to someone? Who Guided you?
- Everyone has an off-week now and then. Is there something you need a break from to get back to a strong start for next week?
- How is your badge compiling going?
- Do you save time to compile badges?
- Where do you feel behind?
- Is there a way I can support you?



FEEDBACK / ASSESSING LEARNING

TOOLS TO MEASURE LEARNING

Points

Weekly points measure time/effort on task.

Badges

Badges represent several weeks of work compiled and reviewed. They are similar to "courses" completed in a traditional community. Badges are significant milestones of learning and represent excellence and progress in learning.

Exhibitions of Learning

Each session concludes with a public exhibition for parents on a particular area of learning. Learners demonstrate their learning through debates, speeches, presentations and demonstrations. They discuss their lessons learned and show their portfolios of work. Your Guides will advise you of each session's exhibition date and time at the beginning of the session.

Badge Plans

These plans are created at the beginning of each year and signed off by Learner and parent. They contain learning goals for progression. Learners will share these with parents twice per year with a Guide at a Journey Meeting. We also encourage parents to check in at home each session and stay in-tune with their children's achievements and struggles.

Journey Meetings

(at the end of every session and twice per year- in person)

These are 20 minute Journey Meetings with Guides and their Learner. The Guide is there to facilitate the conversation between you and your child. You will be given a survey/questionnaire to complete as your "ticket" to secure a meeting. The purpose of this survey is to document your questions and concerns in advance of the meeting in order to ensure the short time in this meeting is spent well and serves you where you most need support.

Calendar

You will receive the Calendar each year that displays the session schedule and breaks.

Parent Meetings

Each year we host three parent meetings. Part of the Parent Contract includes the commitment for one parent from each family to attend at least two of these meetings each year. The purpose of these meetings is a far cry from a typical "P.T.A." meeting. Rather, they are created to inspire you to find your own calling and to be better equipped to help your child maneuver the landscape of his or her own, unique journey.

Do you accept this call to adventure?

20

If you accept, please sign and return.

- [ ] Our Purpose
- [ ] Mission Statement
- [ ] Our Beliefs
- [ ] Our Promises
- [ ] Accountability: Contracts and Covenants
- [ ] Daily Life: Hours, Arrival/Dismissal, Lunch, Chromebooks and Supplies
- [ ] Gatekeeping: Health Policies, Absenteeism, Internet Safety and Social Media
- [ ] Tuition
- [ ] Systems of Accountability (Strikes & Transition Contracts)
- [ ] Staying Informed on my child's learning: Points Tracker, Blogs, Surveys
- [ ] Contacting Guides
- [ ] Feedback/Assessing Learning: Points, 360 Reviews, Exhibitions,
- [ ] Badges Versus Grades
- [ ] Google Calendar
- [ ] Parent Meetings
- [ ] Growth Mindset Article
- [ ] Learner Calendar and Special Events

I hereby acknowledge that I have read and understood the following policies from the Acton Upcountry Family Handbook. I agree to abide by these policies and procedures.

Learner's Name: _____

Parent Signature: _____

Parent Signature: _____

Date: _____

Resources to stay connected

Books:

1. Courage to Grow, by Laura Sandefer, co-founder of Acton Academy Austin
2. Unschooling Rules: 55 Ways to Unlearn What We Know About Schools and Rediscover Education, by Clark Aldrich
3. The One World Schoolhouse: Education Reimagined, by Sal Khan
4. Creative Schools: The Grassroots Revolution That's Transforming Education, by Sir Ken Robinson
5. Mindset: The New Psychology of Success, by Carol S. Dweck
6. NurtureShock: New Thinking About Children, by Po Bronson and Ashley Merryman
7. Work Rules!: Insights from Inside Google that Will Transform How You Live and Lead, by Laszlo Bock, Former Head of People Operations at Google
8. The Talent Code: Greatness Isn't Born. It's Grown. Here's How., by Daniel Coyle
9. The Thomas Jefferson Education: Teaching a Generation of Leaders for the Twenty-First Century, by Oliver DeMille
10. Switch on Your Brain, by Dr. Carolyn Leaf
11. The Anxious Generation, by Jonathan Haidt
12. The Power of Ted, by David Emerald
13. https://www.actonacademykula.com, Acton Upcountry Website
14. https://www.actonacademy.org, Acton Academy Website

Parent & Guide Communication and Observation Policy

ACTON UPCOUNTRY
Courage • Character • Calling

Purpose

Acton Upcountry values open, respectful, and direct communication between families and Guides. Clear communication helps create a supportive environment in which every Learner can learn, grow, and participate successfully.

This policy establishes a consistent process for addressing concerns regarding a Learner's behavior, interactions, or experience at Acton Upcountry. It is intended to ensure that concerns are handled privately, respectfully, and in a manner that protects the dignity and well-being of all Learners involved.

1. Communication Regarding Learner Behavior

When a parent or guardian has a concern regarding the behavior, treatment, or interactions of a Learner, the first step is to communicate directly with the appropriate Guide.

Parents and guardians are encouraged to bring concerns forward promptly rather than allowing concerns to build or attempting to resolve matters independently with other families or Learners.

Communication should remain respectful, factual, and focused on the behavior or situation of concern rather than on personal judgments about another Learner or family.

2. First Step: Meeting with the Guide

The first process for addressing a concern is a meeting with the Guide.

At the Guide's discretion, this meeting may include:

* The parent or guardian raising the concern;
* The parent or guardian of another Learner involved;
* The Learner or Learners involved; and/or
* Other individuals whose participation the Guide determines may be helpful to resolving the concern.

The Guide will determine whether Learners and/or other parents should participate based on what the Guide believes is most appropriate for the Learners and for productive resolution of the concern.

The purpose of the meeting is to understand the situation, hear relevant perspectives, clarify expectations, and determine an appropriate path forward.

3. Notification of Learners Involved

When a parent makes a complaint or raises a formal concern involving the behavior or actions of another Learner, all Learners involved in the concern will be notified that a complaint has been made.

Notification will be handled in an age-appropriate and respectful manner. The purpose of notification is not to assign blame or create conflict, but to ensure that Learners understand that a concern has been raised and that Acton Upcountry is addressing it.

Acton Upcountry will make reasonable efforts to protect the privacy of families and avoid unnecessary disclosure of personal information. However, because concerns may involve multiple Learners, complete confidentiality cannot always be guaranteed.

4. Communication Between Parents

Parents and guardians should not attempt to independently investigate, discipline, confront, or resolve another Learner's behavior.

Parents should also avoid discussing complaints about another Learner with other families, particularly in group messages, social media, or other community forums.

Concerns should be brought to the appropriate Guide so that Acton Upcountry can address them through an appropriate and consistent process.

Parents may communicate directly with another parent when the Guide determines that such communication would be constructive and appropriate. However, the Guide may participate in or facilitate that communication when appropriate.

5. Guide's Role in Addressing Concerns

The Guide will use professional judgment when determining how to respond to a behavioral concern.

Depending on the circumstances, the Guide may:

* Speak privately with the Learner or Learners involved;
* Meet with parents or guardians;
* Facilitate a meeting between families;
* Establish or clarify behavioral expectations;
* Develop a plan for moving forward;
* Monitor the situation over time; or
* Take other appropriate steps to support the Learners and the Acton Upcountry community.

Not every concern will result in the same response. The Guide may consider the age and maturity of the Learners, the nature and severity of the behavior, the circumstances surrounding the incident, previous concerns, and what approach is most likely to support the Learners involved.

6. Studio Observations by Parents

Parents and guardians are welcome to have appropriate opportunities to understand and observe their Learner's experience at Acton Upcountry. However, all parent observations of the studio must be scheduled in advance with the Guide.

Parents may not enter or observe the studio unexpectedly or without prior approval.

The Guide retains discretion to determine:

* When an observation may take place;
* How long an observation may last;
* Where a parent may observe from;
* How frequently observations may occur;
* Whether an observation should be postponed or rescheduled; and
* Whether an observation should be limited or declined based on what the Guide determines is in the best interest of the Learners.

The Guide may limit or modify observation opportunities when the presence of a parent could distract Learners, alter the normal studio environment, interfere with the learning process, affect another Learner's privacy, or otherwise be inconsistent with what the Guide determines is best for the Learners.

An observation is intended to provide parents with appropriate insight into their Learner's experience. It is not an opportunity for a parent to direct the Guide, correct another Learner, intervene in an interaction, or conduct an independent investigation.

7. Respect for the Studio Environment

Parents and guardians are expected to respect the studio as a learning environment.

During an approved observation or visit, parents should:

* Remain in the designated observation area;
* Refrain from communicating with or correcting Learners;
* Refrain from interrupting the Guide;
* Avoid photographing, recording, or sharing images of other Learners without appropriate permission;
* Avoid discussing observations with other families in a manner that could create conflict; and
* Follow any additional instructions provided by the Guide.

8. Escalation of Concerns

If a parent believes that a concern has not been adequately addressed after meeting with the Guide, the parent may request an additional meeting with Acton Upcountry leadership.

The purpose of an escalation is to seek clarification, review the process that has occurred, and determine whether additional action is appropriate.

Parents are expected to allow the Guide an opportunity to address the concern before escalating the matter, except in circumstances involving an immediate safety concern or other situation that reasonably requires prompt attention.

9. Immediate Safety Concerns

Concerns involving immediate threats to the safety or well-being of a Learner should be brought to the attention of the Guide or Acton Upcountry leadership immediately.

Acton Upcountry may take immediate steps to protect Learners while a concern is being reviewed. The normal communication process may be modified when circumstances require an immediate response.

Acknowledgment

By participating in the Acton Upcountry community, parents and guardians agree to follow this communication and observation process and to work cooperatively with Guides and Acton Upcountry leadership to address concerns in a respectful and constructive manner.

Acton Upcountry reserves the right to modify this process when circumstances require a different approach in order to protect the safety, privacy, or well-being of Learners or members of the Acton Upcountry community.